The BJP is growing because the acquisition of power has made it the party of upward mobility and aspiration in middle India. When Brajesh Pathak, once the BSP's deputy leader in the Lok Sabha, switched to the BJP, he explained his motives to the journalist Pranshu Mishra thus: 'A political leader has an average career of 20 years unless you are from a political family. Then it can go up to 30 years. Of 20 I had done 10 in BSP, I will do my remaining 10 in BJP. Congress is good but what's the point in joining it.' He is currently a minister in Yogi Adityanath's government.[78] The RSS too is seeing a similar spurt in growth. As a regional head of the Sangh in UP told me, 'We are growing fast but we are very aware that many people are coming to us because they want the spoils of power. Our job is to figure out which of these are genuine and which ones are here only till we have power.'

The bottom line is that the BJP's vote share in India has never gone below 18 per cent in parliamentary elections since 1991. Between 1999 and 2009, it hovered around the 20 per cent mark. Even when it lost two successive elections in 2004 and 2009, it's 22.2 per cent vote share only fell to 18.8 per cent. 'It didn't become 12–13 per cent,' says Jai Mrug. In 2014, the BJP upped this to 31.3 per cent, and in 2019 to 37.7 per cent. These numbers mean that, in a worst-case scenario, even if one in three voters leave the BJP by 2024, it will still retain over 25 per cent of the vote share. By way of comparison, that is roughly what brought the Congress and Manmohan Singh to power in 2004 (26.5 per cent vote share) and again in 2009 (28.5 per cent vote share). Unless there is a landslide, this is the scale of the challenge for the Opposition.

BJP's Advantage 2: The Congress's Weakness Is an Asset

The BJP's biggest asset is the continuing decline of the Congress as a national party under Sonia and Rahul Gandhi. Engulfed in its leadership crisis, the Congress remains strong in the two-party polity states of the Hindi belt—MP, Chhattisgarh, Uttarakhand, Himachal, Rajasthan—but is a declining force in the South (Telangana, Andhra), where the BJP is replacing it as the main opponent of the regional parties. Outside the Hindi heartland, the real challenge to